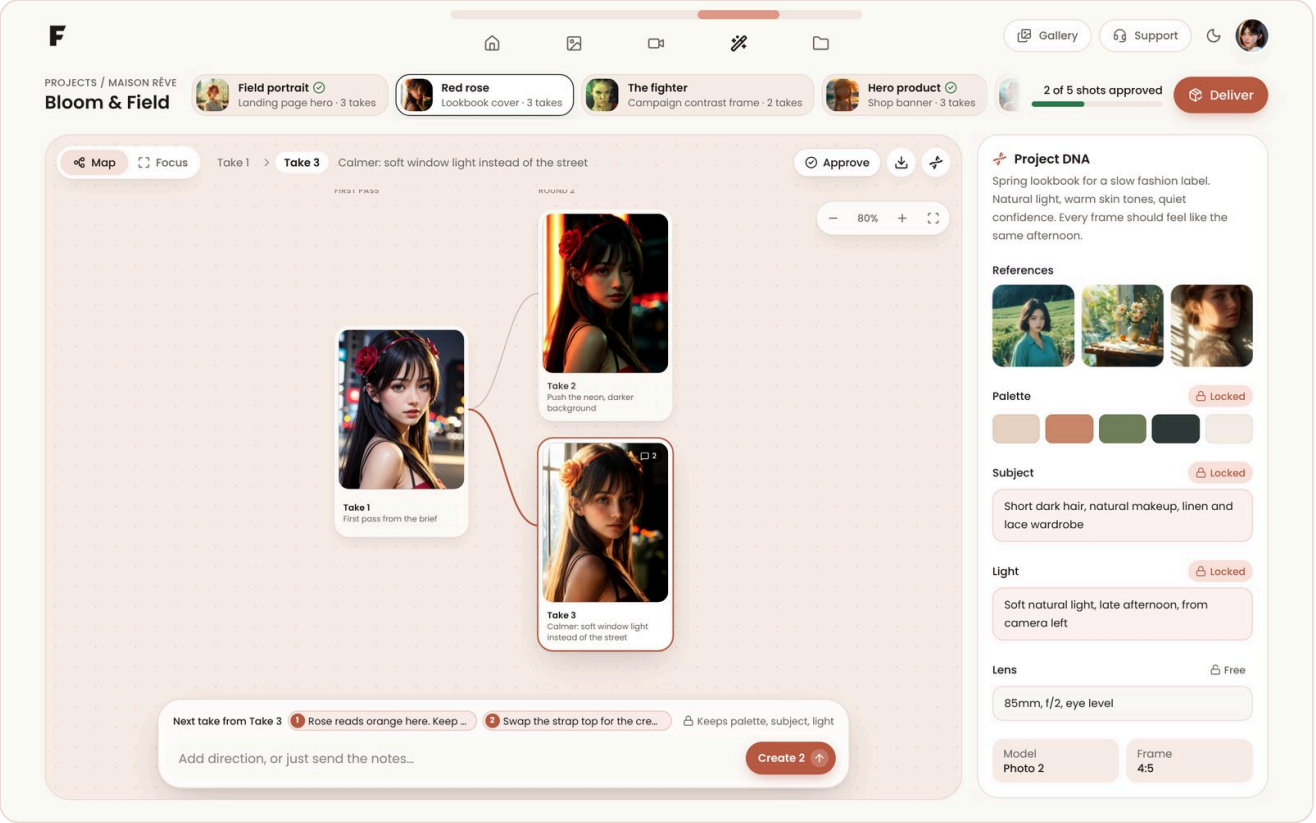
Direction Studio · Product Thinking

Part B of the Fomi frontend assessment. Redesigned workspace: **Image Editing**.

- **Live demo:** Add your Vercel link here (Part B is at `/studio`)
- **Repository:** Add your GitHub link here

The idea in one paragraph

AI models are getting better fast. In a few years making a good image will be cheap and instant, and the hard part of professional work will no longer be *generating*. It will be **deciding**: which version is right, what exactly should change, and how to keep twenty images feeling like one shoot. Direction Studio is an image editing workspace designed for that future. You don't write prompts and scroll a feed. You **direct takes**, and the workspace keeps a visible map of every decision.



The take map: every take of the Red rose shot as a branch, the selected lineage highlighted, the direction bar floating over the canvas and Project DNA on the right.

1. What problem were you trying to solve, and for whom?

The user. A professional who spends hours a day in Fomi: a photographer, brand designer or small studio producing a lookbook, campaign or product catalogue for a client. They are signed in, returning to a project they started yesterday, and they will make dozens of small decisions before anything ships.

The problem. Today's AI tools are built around one prompt and one grid of results. That works for exploring. It breaks down for professional editing:

- **Feedback is spatial, prompts are not.** A client points at the image and says "the rose reads orange here". The professional has to turn that into prompt text and hope only that part changes.
- **Iteration destroys history.** New results push old ones down a feed. When the client says "the version from this morning was better", it is hard to find, and nobody remembers which change led where.
- **Consistency is manual.** Five shots must feel like one afternoon, so users keep the light, palette and subject in their heads and paste them into every prompt.
- **"Done" is invisible.** Nothing says which version of each shot is approved, or how close the project is to delivery.

The job to be done: *"Take a project from first drafts to an approved set of images, with my client's feedback addressed and nothing lost along the way."*

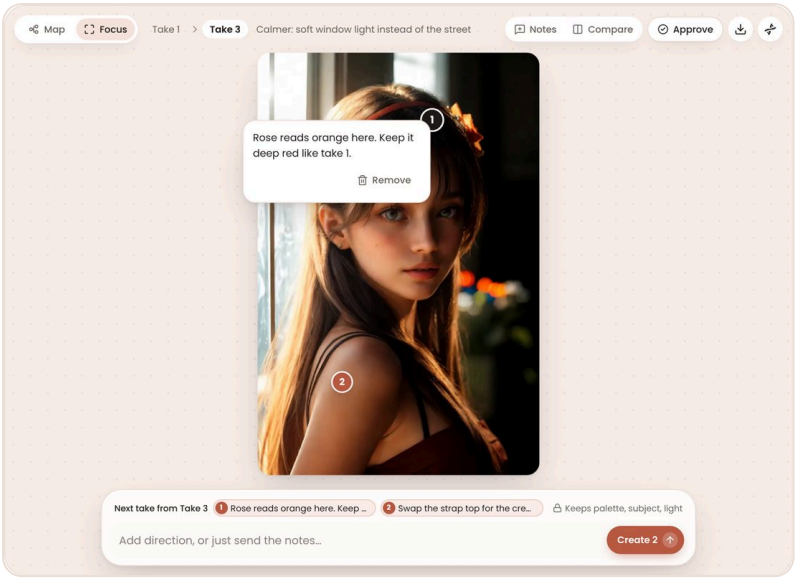
2. The three most important UX decisions

1. The take map: every change is a branch you can see. The centre of the screen is a map of the shot. Each take is a card, laid out left to right by round, joined to the take it came from. The path that led to the selected take is drawn in the accent colour, and a breadcrumb (Take 1 › Take 3 › Take 4) sits above the canvas. Creating takes never overwrites anything: new cards appear as dashed "developing" branches, then develop like a photograph. *Why:* professionals explore more boldly when going back is free, and the map turns "which one was it, and why?" into a glance. Each take's direction text doubles as a change log for the client.

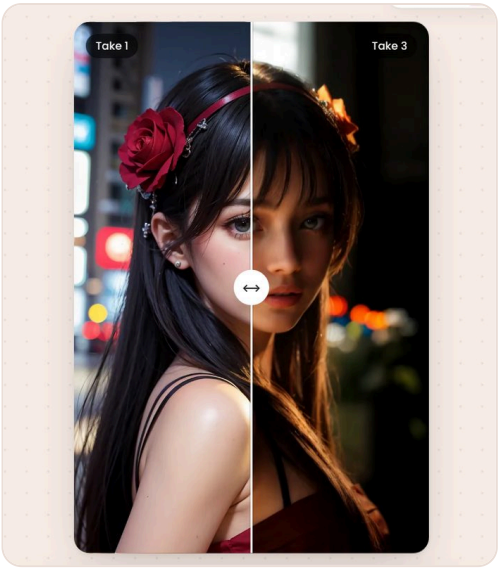
2. Feedback lives on the image and flows straight into the next take. In Focus view, press `N` and click the exact spot to pin a numbered note. The direction bar at the bottom of the canvas picks up every pin of the selected take as a chip, so the next take addresses them automatically; a chip can be clicked to leave that note out. Typing a direction is optional. *Why:* it removes the most error prone step in the workflow, translating visual feedback into words, and keeps the client's exact words attached to the exact version they were about. `C` compares any take with its parent using a before and after slider, so the user can confirm the note was addressed.

3. The project is the unit of work, not the prompt. A project has shots (Field portrait, Red rose, Hero product…). Each shot ships exactly one approved take (`A`). Project DNA holds the references, palette, subject, light and lens, and locked traits carry into every new take. A progress

bar and the Deliver panel show what is ready and what still needs a pick. *Why:* this mirrors how commissioned work is actually run, and moves "keep it consistent" from the user's memory into the tool.



Focus view: pinned notes become chips in the direction bar.



Compare any take with its parent.

3. Which features did you intentionally leave out?

- **Masks, brushes and layers.** Pinned notes cover the common case ("fix this area") with far less effort. Pixel tools are Photoshop's job; this workspace directs a model.
- **Model, guidance and seed controls.** As models improve these matter less, and for a project they are fixed by Project DNA. Part A keeps them for free exploration.
- **Real time collaboration.** The data model (notes, approvals) is ready for it, but multiplayer is a big infrastructure investment that would distract from proving the core loop.
- **A prompt history feed.** The take map replaces it, organised by decision instead of by time.
- **Video.** The same model (shots, takes, notes) applies, but time based notes need their own design.

4. Which existing products inspired your thinking?

- **Figma.** *Liked:* comments pinned to an exact spot, and an infinite canvas you can zoom and pan. *Improve:* Figma comments sit beside the work; here they become the input for the next version.
- **Cursor.** *Liked:* one composer bar where intent goes in and the tool does the rest, with context attached automatically. *Improve:* the direction bar attaches visual context (pins) instead of files.
- **Git and Lightroom virtual copies.** *Liked:* cheap, safe experiments with a clear history. *Improve:* both feel technical. The take map keeps the idea but speaks the language of a shoot: takes, rounds, circled picks.

- **Krea and Higgsfield.** *Liked:* speed and immersion. *Improve:* they are generators; every session starts from a blank prompt and history is a flat feed.
- **Film set language** ("take 3", "circle that take", "the director's notes"). It gives a clear mental model for reviewing many versions of one shot.

The visual language follows Part A (warm palette, soft panels, chips), so the Studio feels like part of Fomi rather than a separate tool.

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5. With another month, what would you improve?

1. **True region editing.** Use each note's coordinates to build a soft mask, so the model changes only the pinned area.
2. **Client review links.** A read only map where the client pins notes and approves takes, which flow straight back into the project.
3. **Usability testing with five working professionals**, focused on turning feedback into the next take, then tune the quick directions and strength presets from real use.
4. **Project DNA that learns.** Suggest locking a trait when the user keeps approving takes that share it.
5. **Engineering:** a real backend with optimistic updates, unit tests for the reducers and map layout, Playwright tests for the core loop, and a keyboard alternative for placing pins.

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6. The single differentiating workflow

Pin → Direct → Branch → Compare → Approve, all on one canvas.

Most AI platforms are prompt first and grid shaped: type, get four images, type again. Direction Studio is decision first. You point at what is wrong, the next takes branch from that exact version with your notes attached, you see the new branch develop on the map, compare it with its parent, and circle the one that ships. The workspace remembers every decision so the professional doesn't have to.

Design trade-offs

What was prioritised

- The core loop end to end. Every step works against the mock API, has loading, error and empty states, and survives a refresh.
- The image as the hero. The map and the focus view use the full canvas; controls float over it or tuck into a drawer.
- Speed for people who use the tool for hours: `F` map or focus, `D` direct, `N` notes, `C` compare, `A` approve, arrow keys on the map, `Enter` to send.
- Meaningful motion only: branches draw from parent to child, new takes develop from soft to sharp, the selected lineage lights up. Each animation explains what just happened. All of it respects reduced motion.

What was simplified

- The mock model returns believable images from a prepared pool for each shot instead of truly editing pixels.
- Project DNA is one panel with a few traits rather than a full style system.
- On phones the same canvas is used with the map scaled down; phones are for reviewing, pinning and approving, heavy work is expected on a larger screen.
- One demo project. A project list was left out because the brief assumes a user returning to an existing project.

What was removed

- A settings sidebar. It made the screen busy and pulled attention from the image.
- A separate tree panel beside the image. An earlier version had one; the map replaced it, which removed a column and made lineage the main view instead of a side list.
- Multiple approvals per shot. One pick per shot keeps delivery unambiguous.
- Onboarding tours. Shortcuts live in the Support menu instead.